

# SUPPLEMENTARY ESSAYS

# BONANZA

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# WHY MAJOR ESSAY EXAMPLES

Living in Eastlands, the most densely populated area of Nairobi, my family regularly faced food shortages, largely because the city was often disconnected from rural agricultural regions. During heavy rains, rural feeder roads flood, severing the connection between farms and main highways. For days on end, transport of perishable crops is impossible. Partly for this reason, I want to pursue Civil and Environmental Engineering at MIT, with the aim of helping to develop Kenya's transportation infrastructure. Professor Moshe Ben-Akiva's research into the future of urban transportation intrigues me, and I also hope to study efficient transportation systems in developing countries.

My decision to major in Electrical Engineering was inspired by my desire to improve security through technology. When I lived in Mexico, my father's restaurant security system lacked the ability to protect our property from robbers, who would break in multiple times a year. Thanks to the influence of my cousin, who now studies Autonomous Systems, I developed an interest in electrical engineering. I am inspired to not only improve my father's security system, but contributing to security innovations for larger companies and perhaps, one day, national security.

***CONTEXT:*** How have your experiences shaped the particular course you seek and in shaping your future endeavours?

***WHAT MAKES THAT MAJOR AT THAT PARTICULAR SCHOOL SPECIAL:*** Is it research by a particular faculty member? Is it how it is taught? Is it a particular program the school has say that offers hands-on experience to students who pursue the major?

***WHAT IMPACT DO YOU HOPE TO HAVE AFTER COMPLETING YOUR STUDIES?***

# EXTRA-CURRICULAR ESSAYS

*'Was Daisy worth it?'*

Answering that question without being in Mr. Gatsby's shoes would be a fallacy. Only in his shoes can I understand what Daisy's love meant. Through acting, I journey through characters' minds. When the curtain falls, I have a deeper understanding of a character's actions. Once after taking the role of Gatsby in a class play, I dare say Daisy's love was worth everything, and I am sure Gatsby (imaginary as he is) welcomes my findings and says *'Man after my own heart, old sport'*.

I look forward to performing roles in plays at The Wedding Cake.

*Did you have a hard time narrowing it down to just one interest or hobby? We understand – Caltech students like to stay busy, too – tell us about another hobby or interest!(50 words)*

In any argument when debating, offering solutions is my backbone. In topics that are perspective-oriented, my main aim is to persuade an audience that the grass is greener on my side of the topic(Haha! Unless it's Nevada). Through Caltech's Debate Society, I will continue engaging audiences through meaningful discussions.



***CONTEXT:*** How have you engaged with said activity in the past? How did it impact you? What did you learn?

***INSTITUTIONAL ENGAGEMENTS:*** Will you continue engaging in the activity in the future? What available opportunities does the school have to enable you engage in this activity more?

# COMMUNITY ESSAY

"What is your profession?" ask a Luo maize roaster.

"I am a monocot-thermal engineer," he would reply proudly.

The Luo community is famous for our hyperbolic nature. However, we are more than that. For instance, fishing has been our pivotal economic activity. Young males are taught how to fish in groups early in life. When we had planned the day's catch, each '*mbese*'(agemate) held to his tasks and was held accountable for flaws in their department. Nevertheless, when a problem arises an individual isn't left to solve it alone. Most of the time, I am usually in charge of responding to engine related issues. Once after transferring the nets back to the boat, the engine failed to start due to fuel blockages. Since I had not carried the boat's toolbox, we had to row back to the shore. I remember being the first to hold an oar. I expected my agemates to be angered by my forgetfulness. Instead, they all opened up to assist me row the boat to the shoreline. A gush of pride filled me about our Luo heritage- our willingness to collaborate for the end goal in the Kenyan spirit of Harambee(pulling together).

The sense of planning, delegation and collaboration instilled in me by my community are skills I intend to continue implementing at Caltech and beyond. In laboratory research, I hope to always outline my objectives, execute tasks delegated to me by my professors and collaborate with my peers to seek scientific truths.

My last name: Pritamani, Mother's maiden name: Kalvani, Grandmother's maiden name: Kewalramani. Almost every Sindhi, along with enjoying shiny clothes, can be identified by the -ani. Though the Sindhi language may be dying, pre-partition Sindhi culture is truly alive with daal pakwan and sale mani being dishes I have learned to make.

Though my roots are Sindh, post-partition most of my family moved to Mumbai, which has now become my "home" in India. I can vividly remember the off-and-on monsoon rains and drinking from fresh nariyal (coconuts) when coming out of Jogger's Park.

I celebrate Diwali, use my Hindi written and spoken skills to read the shudh (pure) Hindi from the prayer books, recount lessons from the Ramayan and Mahabharat, and fast from eggs every Monday as prayer for my parents' long life.

Growing up watching Sunday football, learning and exploring American history.

I am Sindhi, Indian, Hindu, and American.

# ROOMMATE ESSAY

3:13AM

*Hiya roomie! Please forgive the email at this late hour—my energy levels are directly proportional to how late it gets.*

*I figured I'd introduce myself before we meet at NSO. Here are some cool (I hope) things about me:*

*First off, true to my mountainous heritage, I'm quite outdoorsy, having spent many weekends trekking around state parks. I can't wait to explore these uncharted waters—wanna join me on a trip later this week to SLAC?*

*I should warn you beforehand: I explore at an unusually zippy pace and tend to perk up at minor disturbances. That's because a bluebird day in my state can change into a roaring thunderstorm within just a few minutes, turning Fourteener hikers into lightning rods, so I've learned to always be on the lookout.*

*Oh, and no matter what I'm doing, there's always music in the background. You'll notice that I have profound kinetic responses to melodies, which come in the form of flailing my arms during the climactic moments of symphonies. I guess music really does move me!*

*What kind of songs do you like? I love to recreate radio music with my violin—feel free to request a song anytime, and I promise I'll give it my best effort!*

*Lastly, I must share that there are things I will miss as I leave home. Most of all, I will miss biking with my sister around the neighborhood. So, hopefully you won't mind my daily family FaceTimes after each day's festivities!*

*See you soon! :)*

# INTELLECTUAL VITALITY ESSAY

*What's more probable: dying from a shark attack, or dying from falling airplane parts? Surprisingly, the answer is falling airplane parts. But why does our intuition point us towards shark attacks?*

*The answer lies in the availability heuristic, or the WYSIATI ("what you see is all there is") rule, which describes how our minds evaluate decisions based on how easily we can think of examples to support both sides. From Jaws to YouTube surfer videos, we have all likely heard of a horrific shark attack, and by WYSIATI, the ease with which we conjure up that memory leads us to assign greater probability.*

*Learning about WYSIATI evolved the way I communicate my ideas. When I first started debate, I over-focused on comparing statistics at the expense of clearly communicating larger arguments. WYSIATI taught me that a more effective approach involves weaving in memorable images like that of a horrific shark attack. This past summer, when debating whether labeling environmental activists as "eco-terrorists" is justified, my opponents cited dozens of crimes associated with activists from 1995-2002. With my knowledge of WYSIATI, I looked past the numbers and searched for more memorable, image-based examples and discovered that most of the so-called terrorist acts were actually "pie-ings": environmental groups throwing pies to protest. So, instead of responding with only numbers, I declared that "the only thing that could make pie-ings terrorist acts is if the activists didn't know how to make a good key lime pie!"*

*Much clearer. And perhaps, a little bit funnier.*



# ARGUMENTATIVE ESSAY

When I joined the Huntsville Youth Commission, a group of students chosen to represent youth interests within local government, I met Jack. Jack told me his cousin's body had been stuffed into the trunk of a car after he was killed by a gang. After that, my notion of normal would never be the same. A melting pot of ideologies, skins, socio-economic classes, faiths, and educations, the DYC is a unique collaborative enterprise. Although I was initially intimidated after hearing stories like Jack's, I soon realized that the members of the HYC never let difference become an obstacle to understanding. Even now, our experiences are like an elaborate network of roads: weaving, bumping, and diverging in unexpected ways. The Commission allowed us to bring our individual experiences into a shared space of empathy. Jack talked about his cousin's broken body. HYC supervisor Evelyn Scott explained that girls get ten-day school suspensions for simply stepping on another student's sneakers. Witnessa educated us about "food deserts," where people can't count on their next meal. And I talked about being born in Tokyo, moving to London, and living in the south, finding a way to call each place home. How my family's blending of Jewish tradition and Chinese culture—bagels and lox on weekends and dumplings every Lunar New Year—bridges distinct worlds. My experience in this dynamic space of affirmation and engagement has made me a more thoughtful person and listener. Listening empathetically helped us envision multifaceted solutions to issues facing 21st-century youth. I want to continue this effort and be the woman, student, and friend who both expands perspectives and takes action after hearing people's stories. Reconciling disparate lifestyles and backgrounds in the Commission has prepared me to become a compassionate leader, eager to both expand perspectives and take collaborative action.

WHY US/WHY YOU?